

SOUTHERN LATITUDES

THE STARS

The constellation Crux and the two bright stars in Centaurus that act as a pointer to it, Alpha (α) Centauri—or Rigil Kentaurus (see p.252)—and Beta (β) Centauri—Hadar, are high in the southern sky in May. Crux is to the west of the north-south meridian, and Rigil Kentaurus and Hadar are on the eastern side. Although Rigil Kentaurus is usually described as the closest naked-eye star to the Sun, it actually consists of two yellowish stars that form a double star that is easily divided through a small telescope. The brightest member of the Southern Cross, Acrux—Alpha (α) Crucis—is also a double star that is divisible with a small telescope, but its component stars are blue-white.

Spica, in Virgo, lies high overhead with orange Arcturus, in Boötes, in the north. Leo sinks toward the northwestern horizon, while in the southeast, Scorpius and Sagittarius are coming into view—a sign that the southern winter is approaching.

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

The largest and brightest globular cluster in the sky, NGC 5139, or Omega (ω) Centauri, appears to the naked eye as a hazy

4th-magnitude star lying virtually on the north-south meridian this month. To the north of it lies NGC 5128, a peculiar radio-emitting galaxy also known as Centaurus A (see p.322), which is one of the easiest galaxies to find with binoculars. Another bright galaxy located near the meridian is M83, a spiral galaxy that is positioned face-on to Earth.

In Crux, the dark Coalsack Nebula and the sparkling Jewel Box (see p.294) remain prominent.

METEOR SHOWER

The Eta Aquariid meteor shower reaches its peak around May 5–6, when 30 or so fast-moving meteors can be seen radiating each hour from near the star Eta (η) Aquarii, located almost exactly on the celestial equator. However, this part of the sky does not rise very high until around 3 A.M., and the meteor

shower is best seen from equatorial and southerly locations, where May nights are longer. The Eta Aquariids are caused by dust from Halley's Comet (see p.217).

RICH STAR FIELDS

Alpha (α) and Beta (β) Centauri (left) point toward the constellation Crux (right). The Coalsack Nebula (bottom right), most of which lies within Crux, obscures a large area of stars in the Milky Way.

